

What makes a healthy relationship?

Whether a person is going to the movies with a friend or sharing a meal on a date, the same principles of respect, equality, trust, and safety apply to the relationship.

1. Supporting each other

In the best possible relationships, people feel supported by the other person and offer support back. This support can be emotional, social, psychological, academic, creative, or professional. Some relationships offer one or the other, while others—such as romantic interests—offer a mixture. When both people are guided by what is best for each other, they can thrive and shine, both in the relationship and in their personal endeavors.



2. Spending time together

Spending time together is an important part of a healthy relationship. Whether that time is spent online or in person, at school or at work, with others or just as a pair, it shows that an individual cares for another person, and that the feeling is reciprocated. Regardless of whether two people are in a romantic relationship or are platonic friends at school, the time that they spend together should make them feel good about themselves, the other person, and the relationship itself.



3. Maintaining healthy boundaries

Everyone is entitled to privacy, and setting boundaries is one way to maintain a healthy relationship. The boundaries may relate to personal space preferences or how much time is spent together. When two people set boundaries, it helps the individuals to know what they both want and expect from the relationship—especially when the two people are romantically involved. Boundaries should be set by both people together.



4. Communicating openly

Communication in a healthy relationship draws on respect, equality, safety, and trust. It puts them into language, including choice of vocabulary, tone of voice, body language, and listening. In a strong relationship, both people feel able to talk about any worries and frustrations. This openness helps show respect for both people's feelings and opinions, equality in being able to talk on equal terms, trust in the other person to listen, and safety to voice any concerns.

